

Word family: **free / freer / freest / freely / freedom / freebie**

Base word: free

Comparative: freer

Superlative: freest

Related forms: freely, freedom, freebie

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / adverb-related form (相關副詞) / noun-related forms (相關名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Ryan was the one who walked up to me, asked whether the seat beside me was **free**...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **free** means **available and not currently occupied or being used by someone else**.

Ryan was asking whether the seat beside the speaker was empty and available for him to sit in.

繁體中文： **目前沒有人使用、佔用或預留，因此可以讓別人使用的；空著的 / 可用的**

中文翻譯：

> “...asked whether the seat beside me was **free**...”

「.....問我旁邊的座位是不是**空着 / 沒有人坐**.....」

Here:

a free seat = 沒有人佔用、可以讓別人坐下的座位

1. **free = available / not occupied (位置 / 時間 / 資源) — 空着的；有空的；可用的**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Not currently occupied, reserved, used, or committed, and therefore available.

Practice 1 — Original

> “He asked whether the seat beside me was **free**.”

「他問我旁邊的座位是不是**空着 / 沒有人坐**。」

Practice 2

> “Is this table **free**?”

「這張桌子**有人用嗎 / 空着嗎**？」

Practice 3

> “Are you **free** this afternoon?”

「你今天下午**有空嗎**？」

free = 沒有被人佔用、使用、預約或安排，因此可以使用或安排

Common:

- * free seat
- * free table
- * free room
- * free time
- * be free this evening

These share the broad concept:

> **available** because nothing else currently occupies or commits it

The Chinese changes naturally by context:

- * free seat → 空位
- * free room → 空房 / 可用房間
- * free time → 空閒時間
- * Are you free? → 你有空嗎？

Under the Golden Manual, these should not be split merely because the noun changes when the same semantic concept still applies.

2. **free** = costing no money (價格) — 免費的；不用付款的

This is one of the most common meanings.

Meaning: Provided without requiring payment.

Practice 4

> “The museum offers **free** entry on Sundays.”

「博物館星期日提供**免費入場**。」

Practice 5

> “The hotel provides **free** Wi-Fi.”

「酒店提供**免費 Wi-Fi**。」

****free = 不需要支付金錢便可以取得、使用或參與的****

Common:

* free admission

* free delivery

* free sample

* free service

* free trial

This is clearly different from:

> ****a free seat****

A seat can be available but still require payment.

3. ****free = not controlled / able to act as one chooses (自由) — 自由的 ; 不受控制的****

****Meaning:**** Able to make choices or act without being controlled, restricted, or forced by another person or authority.

Practice 6

> “People should be ****free**** to express their opinions.”

「人們應該有****自由****表達意見。」

Practice 7

> “She felt ****free**** to make her own decisions.”

「她覺得自己可以****自由地****作出自己的決定。」

****free = 不受他人強迫、控制或不合理限制，可以自行選擇和行動的****

This is a major distinct sense.

4. **free** = not imprisoned / physically confined (拘禁) — 自由的 ; 獲釋的

A person can be **free** when no longer imprisoned, detained, trapped, or physically restrained.

Practice 8

> “The prisoner was finally **free**.”

「那名囚犯終於**獲得自由 / 被釋放**。」

Practice 9

> “The bird was set **free**.”

「那隻鳥被**放生 / 放走**了。」

free = 不再被囚禁、扣留、困住或限制身體活動

This develops from the broader freedom sense, but for learners it is concrete and important enough to show explicitly.

For core counting, I would probably merge this with Meaning 3 under:

> **absence of restriction/control**

unless your database wants to distinguish civic/personal freedom from physical release.

5. **free of/from + problem/substance** (沒有某物) — 不含 ; 免受 ; 沒有

This is a very productive and important pattern.

Meaning: Not containing, affected by, or suffering from a particular unwanted thing.

Practice 10

> “The product is **free from** artificial colouring.”

「這件產品**不含**人工色素。」

Practice 11

> “She is finally **free of** debt.”

「她終於**擺脫債務 / 沒有債務**了。」

free of/from something = 沒有某種成分、問題、負擔、疾病或限制

Common:

* free from stress

* free of charge

* free from errors

* sugar-free

* smoke-free

* duty-free

The core idea is:

> **absence of something**

This is genuinely different from “available” and “costing nothing.”

6. **-free in compounds (無.....的) — 不含..... ; 沒有.....**

A very productive compound use develops from Meaning 5.

Practice 12

> “This drink is sugar-**free**.”

「這款飲品是**無糖的**。」

Practice 13

> “The building is smoke-**free**.”

「這座建築是**全面禁煙 / 無煙的**。」

X-free = 沒有、不含或避免某種指定物質、狀況或限制

Common:

* sugar-free

* fat-free

- * smoke-free
- * tax-free
- * duty-free
- * error-free

For database counting, I would merge these under the broader:

> ****without / not containing****

sense.

7. ****free = released from duty/obligation (責任 / 工作) — 不用做 ; 免除 ; 沒有責任****

****Free**** can mean no longer required to perform a duty, obligation, or task.

Practice 14

> “Once the meeting ends, you are ****free to leave****.”

「會議結束後，你就****可以自由離開 / 不必再留下****。」

Practice 15

> “He is now ****free from**** his previous responsibilities.”

「他現在已經****不用再負責 / 擺脫了****以前那些責任。」

****free = 不再受到某項工作、責任、義務或要求約束****

This is closely related to the broader ****absence of restriction/obligation**** concept.

8. ****free = unrestricted / unlimited in movement or flow (活動 / 流動) — 自由流動的 ; 暢通的****

Something can move or operate ****freely**** when nothing blocks it.

Practice 16

> “Make sure the wheels can move ****freely****.”

「確保車輪可以****自由轉動 / 暢順活動****。」

Practice 17

> “Air must be able to flow **freely** through the room.”

「空氣必須能夠在房間內**自由流通**。」

free/freely = 沒有受到物理阻礙或限制，可以順暢移動或流動

This is a physical extension of the broader freedom sense.

9. **free** = unrestricted/open access (使用 / 存取) — 公開可用的；不受限制的

In some contexts, **free** means access is unrestricted or open.

Practice 18

> “Citizens have **free access** to the public library.”

「市民可以**自由使用 / 不受限制地進入**公共圖書館。」

Practice 19

> “The information is **freely available** online.”

「這些資料可以在網上**自由取得 / 公開查閱**。」

free access = 不受不必要限制，可以公開或自由進入、取得或使用

This is distinct from **free = no cost** because:

> **free access**

may emphasize permission rather than price.

Related form: **freely**

Freely has two especially useful branches.

freely = without restriction (自由地)

Practice 20

> “Students may move **freely** between the rooms.”

「學生可以在房間之間**自由走動**。」

Practice 21

> “She spoke **freely** about her experiences.”

「她**毫無拘束地 / 自由地**談自己的經歷。」

****freely = 不受限制、阻礙或壓力地****

**freely = willingly / generously (慷慨地 ; 毫不吝嗇地) **

Practice 22

> “He **freely** shared his knowledge with younger colleagues.”

「他**毫不吝嗇地**跟年輕同事分享自己的知識。」

Practice 23

> “She gives her time **freely** to help others.”

「她很**樂意 / 慷慨地**付出自己的時間幫助別人。」

****freely = 自願而沒有保留地給予、分享或表達****

This is a useful figurative extension.

Related form: **freedom**

****Freedom** means the condition or right of being free.**

Practice 24

> “The job gives her more **freedom**.”

「這份工作給她更多**自由**。」

Practice 25

> “Children need some **freedom** to make their own choices.”

「孩子需要一定的**自由**去作自己的選擇。」

****freedom = 不受不必要限制、控制或強迫，可以自行行動和選擇的狀態 / 權利****

Related form: ****freebie****

****Freebie**** is informal.

It means something given without charge.

Practice 26

> “The company handed out ****freebies**** at the event.”

「公司在活動上派發了一些****免費贈品****。」

Practice 27

> “Everyone loves a ****freebie****.”

「人人都喜歡****免費贈品****。」

****freebie = 免費送出的商品、樣本或其他東西；口語****

Fixed expression: ****free of charge — 免費****

Practice 28

> “Children can enter ****free of charge****.”

「兒童可以****免費入場****。」

Practice 29

> “The service is provided ****free of charge****.”

「這項服務是****免費提供的****。」

****free of charge = 不需要支付任何費用****

This belongs to the ****no-cost**** sense.

Fixed expression: **set someone/something free — 釋放**

Practice 30

> “They **set the animal free**.”

「他們把那隻動物**放走 / 放生**。」

Practice 31

> “The prisoners were eventually **set free**.”

「那些囚犯最終被**釋放**。」

set free = 令某人或某物脫離拘禁、限制或困住狀態

This belongs to the freedom/release sense.

Fixed expression: **feel free to + verb — 儘管；可以隨意**

Practice 32

> “**Feel free to** ask questions.”

「有問題的話**儘管問 / 可以隨意問**。」

Practice 33

> “Please **feel free to** contact me anytime.”

「請**隨時 / 儘管**聯絡我。」

feel free to do something = 不必覺得受到限制或不好意思，可以放心做某件事

This is an important fixed construction rather than a separate core meaning.

Important distinction: **free vs available**

This is especially relevant to your original sentence.

free

can mean:

> not occupied / not committed

available

means:

> able to be used, obtained, or contacted

They often overlap:

> “Is this seat free?”

> “Is this seat available?”

Both can mean:

「這個座位有人嗎 / 可用嗎？」

But **free** also has many meanings that **available** does not:

* free speech

* free sample

* set free

* sugar-free

Important distinction: **free vs empty**

free seat

= nobody is using it; available

empty seat

= nobody is physically sitting in it

These often describe the same situation, but not always.

A seat may be:

> empty but reserved

So it is not necessarily:

> free

This distinction is especially important for your sentence.

Important distinction: **free vs complimentary**

free

= costs nothing

complimentary

= provided free by a business or organization, often as a service or courtesy

> free drink

broad.

> complimentary drink

specifically provided by the establishment at no charge.

Important distinction: **free vs freedom**

free

= adjective describing a person/thing

> "She is free."

freedom

= noun describing the condition/right

> "She values her freedom."

So:

free = 自由的

****freedom = 自由這種狀態 / 權利****

Important distinction: ****free vs freely****

**free**

usually adjective:

> “You are free to leave.”

**freely**

adverb:

> “You may speak freely.”

The first describes the person's state or permission; the second describes how the action is performed.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* ****free****

* ****freer****

* ****freest****

* ****freely****

* ****freedom****

* ****freebie****

Useful constructions and compounds include:

* free seat

* free time

* free entry

* free speech

* free access

* free from

* free of

* sugar-free

* smoke-free

- * free of charge
- * set free
- * feel free to

The Golden Manual says broad grammatical constructions and productive compounds should be checked, but overlapping uses should still be merged when the same underlying semantic idea explains them.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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free — available/not occupied	沒有被人佔用、使用、預約或安排，因此可以使用或安排
free — no cost	不需要支付金錢便可以取得、使用或參與的
free — not controlled/restricted	不受他人強迫、控制或限制，可以自行選擇和行動的
free — not imprisoned/confined	不再被囚禁、扣留、困住或限制身體活動的；屬於 freedom 義
free of/from something	沒有某種成分、問題、負擔、疾病或限制
X-free	不含、沒有或避免某種指定物質 / 情況的
free — released from obligation	不再受到某項責任、工作或義務約束
free access / move freely	不受阻礙或限制，可以自由進入、取得、使用或移動
freely — willingly	自願、沒有保留或毫不吝嗇地
freedom	不受不必要限制或控制，可以自行行動和選擇的狀態或權利
freebie	免費提供的商品、贈品或樣本；口語

For your original sentence

> "...asked whether the ****seat**** beside me was ****free****..."

The exact meaning is:

****free = 沒有人正在使用、佔用或預留，因此可以讓別人使用****

More specifically:

****a free seat = 沒有人坐、也可以讓另一個人坐下的座位****

So:

> ****Is this seat free?****

= **這個座位有人坐嗎 / 這個位可以坐嗎？**

For your database, I would count **6 genuinely useful core meanings** for **free**:

1. **available / not occupied or committed**
2. **costing no money**
3. **not controlled or restricted; able to act freely**
4. **not imprisoned/confined; released**
5. **free of/from something — without or not containing something**
6. **released from duty, responsibility, or obligation**

I would merge **free access / move freely** into the broader unrestricted sense, merge **sugar-free / smoke-free / duty-free** under #5, and treat **feel free to, set free, free of charge**, and **freebie** as fixed or family extensions rather than inflate the core count.